caption comes up: Real Madrid 3 Athletic Bilbao 1. Just as well: I've got the sound turned down.

And it's only then that I realize. I'm watching Real keep the ball for minutes at a time, passing amongst themselves, twisting and turning away from challenges, playing out the twenty minutes that remain. Thousands of miles away, Real are winning La Liga, right now. Because of the time difference, I'm watching it live in the middle of my night. The final whistle goes and the celebrations begin. Streamers and confetti come cascading down from the stands. Fireworks explode over Madrid. The floodlights snap out, everything goes black– for a moment I think there's something wrong with my television—and then spotlights pick out the Real players, all in t-shirts, white as their uniform, saying: 'Campeones 29'. They carry the trophy—their trophy—along the touchline, dancing around it, holding it up to the four corners of the Bernabeu.

I'm breathless watching. Gasping at the spectacle. Gasping at the sight of my future. I glance across and can just make out the outline of Victoria under the bedcovers: my wife's still sleeping tight. No need to wake her, even for this. We'll be there soon enough.

I'm sitting alone, knees tucked up under my chin now; perched on my chair in front of the television as the air cools before morning. I shiver and then I'm aware I've got this huge smile on my face: a boy from Chingford, England. United born and bred. And going to play for Real Madrid.